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THEOLOGICAL METHOD IN IRENAEUS (*ADVERSUS HAERESSES* 2. 25–28)

THERE occurs in Irenaeus' second book against the heresies a section that amounts to a small tractate on theological method (*Adv. haer.* 2. 25–28). It is remarkable especially because it discusses in some detail the limits of reason in theology and significantly restricts the pursuit of metaphysical issues. An investigation of the doxographical sources for one passage in this section led Robert Grant to suggest that Irenaeus here 'inclines toward Scepticism'.¹ More recently W. C. van Unnik has argued that 'the experiment with doxographical knowledge did not lead to scepticism, but to differentiation in our human knowledge of physical phenomena: some things are known, other things are not'.² The present study attempts to show how the opinions of Grant and van Unnik can be reconciled through a fuller understanding of Irenaeus' intellectual background and his way of putting it to work. Especially noteworthy, perhaps, is Irenaeus' indebtedness to the methodological orientation of Empiric medicine.

1. *Knowing 'that' and knowing 'how'*

We begin with what must be regarded as the theological climax of the section—namely, that we often know 'that' such-and-such is so without knowing 'how' it is so (*Adv. haer.* 2. 28. 7). Thus we can say 'that' (*quoniam* = ὅτι)³ God brought forth matter, but we do not know 'whence' (*unde*) or 'how' (*quemadmodum* = πῶς)⁴ he did so. Such inquiries only lead to 'making infinite conjectures' and should be left to God. Similarly we ought to give up investigating the 'cause for which' (*causam propter quam*) some things of God's creation went astray or of 'what nature' (*cuius naturae*) they (and their counterparts) are. Moreover, the Scriptures teach us 'that' (*quoniam*) eternal fire has been prepared for transgressors and 'that'

¹ Robert M. Grant, 'Irenaeus and Hellenistic Culture', in *After the New Testament* (Philadelphia: Fortress Press, 1967), pp. 158–64; cf. *Miracle and Natural Law* (Amsterdam: North-Holland Publishing Company, 1952), pp. 80–1.

² W. C. van Unnik, 'Theological Speculation and Its Limits', in *Early Christian Literature and the Classical Tradition, In Honorem Robert M. Grant*, ed. William R. Schoedel and Robert L. Wilken (Théologie historique 53; Paris: Éditions Beauchesne, 1979), p. 43.

³ Cf. Bruno Reynders, *Lexique comparé de l'Adversus Haereses de saint Irénée* (2 vols.; CSCO 141–2; Subsidia 5–6; Louvain: L. Durbecq, 1954), vol. i, p. 84; vol. ii, p. 272.

⁴ Cf. *ibid.*, vol. i, p. 92, vol. ii, p. 266.

(*quoniam*) God foreknew that this would be, but we are not told 'how' (*quemadmodum*) God prepared the eternal fire for them from the beginning, and no information is provided us as to the 'very cause of the nature' (*ipsam causam naturae*) of such transgressors.

The same thought underlies what Irenaeus writes about God and his Son in what immediately precedes (*Adv. haer.* 2. 28. 4–6): Against the presumed anthropomorphism of the Gnostics we may say (with Xenophanes)⁵ that God is 'all mind, all reason, and all operative spirit and all light and always the same and similarly so' and that thus he transcends standard modes of thought. The failure to realize this causes Gnostics (according to Irenaeus) to resort to the theory of emanations to explain our world and in so doing to claim to know more than can possibly be known about such things. In particular, there can be no answer to the question, 'How (*quomodo*), then, was the Son brought forth from the Father?'

Two closely related parallels illuminate this distinction between knowing 'that' and knowing 'how'. One is found in a Greek fragment from Galen's treatise *On Medical Experience* (preserved in full only in Arabic).⁶ In this part of the treatise the representative of Empiric medicine is speaking and contrasting the method of his school with that of the Dogmatists. He says that there are two possibilities: to discover something through observation alone (the Empiric approach) and to investigate 'how' (*πῶς*) things came about (the Dogmatic approach). He rejects the latter. 'For our effort is not concerning *how* each thing becomes systematic knowledge (*περὶ τοῦ πῶς ἕκαστον γίνεται τεχνικόν*) but only *that* it becomes (*ἀλλ' ὅτι γίνεται μόνον*) what we can clearly consider as agreed on.' He goes on to say that only the Dogmatist 'who fusses over causes' (*ὁ τὰς αἰτίας πολυπραγμονῶν*) has the responsibility 'to teach "how"' (*τὸ πῶς ἐκδιδάσκειν*). Such a person, he warns, risks falling into the absurdity of those who say that since they do not know 'how' (*ὅπως*) they see, they do not see; or that since they do not know 'how' (*τίνα τρόπον*) things come into being, pass away, or move, there is no genesis, corruption, or movement. Empiricists, on the other hand, are satisfied to catalogue what has often been observed in medical practice, familiarizing themselves with

⁵ Frag. 24; Hermann Diels, *Die Fragmente der Vorsokratiker* (3 vols.; 6th edn. Walther Kranz; Berlin: Weidmannsche Verlagsbuchhandlung, 1951–2), vol. i, p. 135. The formula is also an important element in Irenaeus' argument elsewhere (cf. *Adv. haer.* 2. 13. 8).

⁶ R. Walzer, *Galen on Medical Experience* (London, New York, Toronto: Oxford University Press, 1944), pp. 113–14. The Greek text is printed by Walzer as part of section 15 of the translation. It may also be found as fragment 23b in Karl Deichgräber, *Die griechische Empirikerschule* (Berlin: Weidmannsche Buchhandlung, 1930), pp. 101–4.

the emerging patterns, and to refrain from causal explanation. For 'nature', as Celsus (the medical writer) has them say, 'is not comprehensible' (*De med.*, prooem. 27). In this connection, they regard 'learning the nature' (*φύσιν ἐκμαθεῖν*) of the body and seeking the causes of sickness or health as corollaries;⁷ and they lump together investigations into the nature (*φύσις*) of the body, the genesis (*γένεσις*) of disease, and the power (*δύναμις*) of cures.⁸ Thus one critic of the Empiric school says that its members are like 'laymen' (*ιδιωταί*) who marvel at 'what occurs' (*τὸ γιγνόμενον*) and are ignorant of 'the cause of what occurs' (*τοῦ γιγνομένου αἰτίαν*).⁹ But this is precisely the attitude of which Irenaeus approves. For he asserts that it is better to be 'laymen and unlearned' (*ιδιωταί καὶ ὀλιγομαθεῖς*) than speciously learned: 'it is better for a person to believe in God knowing nothing at all, not even a single cause of one of the things that have been made (as to) why it has been made' (*Adv. haer.* 2. 26. 1).

Our second parallel is found in a discussion of the difference between Sceptic and Dogmatic philosophy in Diogenes Laertius' account of Pyrrho (*Vit.* 9. 102–5).¹⁰ That it should occur here is not surprising in the light of the overlap between philosophical Scepticism and Empiric medicine.¹¹ Sextus Empiricus, as his cognomen indicates, was a physician of the Empiric school. To the Dogmatist's charge that Sceptics cannot escape dogmatizing (9. 102), the latter reply that they recognize what is given in experience but suspend judgment about all that is unclear (9. 103). Sceptics, then, claim to know only the effects: 'for we assent to the proposition *that* we see (*ὅτι ὁρώμεν*) and we know *that* we understand this or that (*ὅτι τόδε νοοῦμεν*), but we do not know *how* we see (*πῶς δ' ὁρώμεν*) or how we understand (*πῶς νοοῦμεν*)' (9. 103). The Sceptical attitude, it is claimed, does not make human life impossible since Sceptics do not deny the fact of seeing but only our knowledge of 'how' (*πῶς*) seeing takes place (9. 104). The point is emphasized by other examples of the distinction between knowing 'that' and knowing 'how' (9. 105).

When our source says that Sceptics suspend judgment about what is 'unclear' (9. 103), the term used—*ἄδηλα*—is that regularly found also in medical writings to refer to those hidden processes for which explanations are attempted by the Dogmatists (foolishly in

⁷ Galen, *De sectis* 3 (ed. Helmreich, p. 4. 18).

⁸ Ibid. 5 (p. 10. 6).

⁹ Deichgräber, *Empirikerschule*, p. 117, frag. 35.

¹⁰ The parallel is noted *ibid.*, p. 102.

¹¹ Ibid., pp. 279–81.

the eyes of Empiricists).¹² Thus Sceptics agree with the Empiricists that such things cannot be known.¹³ They were inclined, therefore, to deny the very reality of causes or at least to claim that if causes are real, they are beyond our knowledge.¹⁴ Irenaeus, then, was not alone in emphasizing the problematic character of the search for causes.

There are passages other than those noted above in which Irenaeus shows himself equally impressed by the difficulty of causal explanation.¹⁵ One of these develops a number of important points (*Adv. haer.* 2. 28. 2). It is Irenaeus' basic concern in this passage to show that it is not surprising that we lack understanding of the mysteries of spiritual and heavenly things and things revealed in Scripture, for we are also unable to deal adequately even with the things here at our feet (cf. *Adv. haer.* 2. 28. 9). It is a thought that had occurred already to the writer of Wisdom: 'And only with difficulty do we guess at things on earth, and things in our hands we find with labour; but who has traced out things in heaven?' (ix. 16).¹⁶ On this point, Irenaeus and the book of Wisdom are probably both indebted to a popular theme (discussed below) that pokes fun at those who scan the heavens only to fall flat on their faces here below. But Irenaeus develops the thought in a distinctive way. First of all, he lists a number of topics concerning natural history, doxographical in origin,¹⁷ that puzzled ancient man. What interests us about the list is that although Irenaeus takes it for granted that there is a cause for the rise of the Nile, the phenomenon of tides, and so on down the line, he warns against the assumption that any of our opinions about such causes is to be trusted. Hence he concludes the passage by remarking: 'in all these things we shall not chatter away seeking their causes (*non quidem loquaces erimus requirentes causas eorum*); only God who made them is to be believed'. He goes on in the next paragraph to comment that since even as regards things in creation some 'are reserved for God' whereas others 'have come into our knowledge', we should not be surprised as regards things in

¹² Cf. Deichgräber, *Empirikerschule*, p. 357 (s.v. ἄδηλος).

¹³ The two schools were set apart in this respect from the mainstream. Even 'Epicurus and the Stoics thought it possible to find the causes indirectly by the effects' (C. J. de Vogel, *Greek Philosophy*, vol. iii: *The Hellenistic-Roman Period* [Leiden: E. J. Brill, 1959], p. 220).

¹⁴ Sextus Empiricus, *Pyrrh. hyp.* 3. 13-29; cf. *Adv. math.* 9. 219-26.

¹⁵ *Adv. haer.* 2. 25. 3; 2. 28. 2; 2. 28. 9.

¹⁶ Van Unnik draws attention to the passage but is inclined to see it as more sceptical than Irenaeus about the possibility of men's knowledge of things ('Theological Speculation', pp. 41-2). In my view, it is Irenaeus who raises the more fundamental doubts by explicitly attacking the search for causes.

¹⁷ See n. 1.

Scripture that there are some that 'we explain by the grace of God' and others that are 'reserved for God not only in the present age but also in the age to come' (*Adv. haer.* 2. 28. 3). From what follows (as well as from what is said elsewhere in the section) it is clear that Irenaeus is particularly concerned about the use to which Gnostics were putting the parables of the New Testament.

It seems unlikely (in the light of the points developed at the beginning of this paper) that what Irenaeus has in mind in this passage is merely a distinction between relatively difficult problems and relatively easy ones in the investigation of nature and in Scriptural exegesis. Rather, it would be more in line with his thought if as regards things in nature it is their causes that 'are reserved for God' and the events themselves that 'have come into our knowledge'. Similarly, as regards things in Scripture, it seems likely that the basic contrast is between the assertions of Scripture—for example, that there is one God who brought forth matter—and speculation about such assertions—for example, just whence or how God brought forth matter. We have already discussed this and other examples in commenting on *Adv. haer.* 2. 28. 7 above. In support of this interpretation is the fact that Irenaeus has previously lumped together 'what falls under our glance'¹⁸ with 'what has been said clearly and unambiguously in so many words in the divine Scriptures' (*Adv. haer.* 2. 27. 1).

The one difficulty with this approach to the passage is the fact that Irenaeus is concerned particularly about the interpretation of parables and at times seems to have no more in mind than degrees of exegetical difficulty. Yet his displeasure with the Gnostic interpretation of the parables is intimately linked with his fear of speculation. Note that just after the reference to the problem of the parables in *Adv. haer.* 2. 28. 3 he goes on: 'For example (*ut puta*), if any one asks, "What was God doing before he made the world?", we shall say that the answer lies with God.' Here (as will become clear presently) we have to do with a speculative question taken by Irenaeus to reflect the mind of persons unwilling to accept the words of Scripture at face value. The important point, then, is that when Irenaeus worries about the Gnostic interpretation of parables, it is because such exegesis reflects dissatisfaction with knowing 'that' and an unhealthy desire to know 'why'.

Irenaeus may well think that the parables in fact hint at the reasons for things. And he evidently believes that such mysteries will be revealed to man, though only gradually and never exhaustively, in the age to come. For after saying that some

¹⁸ The expression (as we shall see presently) refers to what we can know without pretending to understand causes.

Scriptural matters are reserved for God not only in this world but also in the next, he adds: 'so that God may always teach, and man may for ever learn from God' (*Adv. haer.* 2. 28. 3). At the same time, the burden of his argument is that the parables cannot be out of harmony with the rest of Scripture. What he means is illustrated by his treatment of the parables in *Adv. haer.* 4. 36-41, where he shows how they too proclaim the oneness of God. Yet it is interesting to observe that in this very section he also develops a daring form of the free-will argument to explain why man was not created perfect (*Adv. haer.* 4. 37-9: 'God shows his kindness in dealing with man's rebellion, for man is educated by means of it . . .'). Thus he does not himself refrain from an attempt to account for the deepest mysteries of human existence in connection with an interpretation of the parables. Yet it is an account that works within a framework provided by the clear words of Scripture (that there is one God), and it may be that Irenaeus would have considered it as no more than a rough indication of what we shall some day come to know.

The eschatological element in Irenaeus' thought introduces a problematic for which there is no parallel in the Empiric tradition. For the Empiricists kept their eyes fixed resolutely on this world. Nevertheless, the exegetical approach recommended by Irenaeus in this section is in harmony with rules developed by the Empiricists for the pursuit of knowledge.

His basic recommendation is that the parables be 'conformed to what is not ambiguous' rather than read in the light of 'what is not said openly nor is set before our eyes' (such as the secret tradition claimed by the Gnostics). Thus all the Scriptures (prophets and gospels) can be heard to say 'openly, without ambiguity and similarly by all' that there is one God. And nature itself, 'through that which comes under our glance', makes the same point (*Adv. haer.* 2. 27. 1). One builds, then, on what is clear in attempting to solve difficulties. To do otherwise (as the Gnostics do) is to subvert 'the very art of discovery' (*ipsam inventionis . . . disciplinam*).

Now it was long known, as Herodotus attests, that it is a safe rule to 'judge the unknown from the plain' (*Hist.* 2. 33. 2).¹⁹ But the Empiricists had more precise views about such matters. The basic guide, of course, was for them 'seeing with one's own eyes' (*αὐτοψία*). At the same time, they realized that things were not always that simple. Thus under some circumstances they also recommended 'inference from what is like' (*ἡ τοῦ ὁμοίου μετάβασις*). One important source describes such inference as a 'way to

¹⁹ Unfortunately, his example indicates the possible imprecision of the rule. For he judges the (unknown) length of the Nile from the (known) length of the Ister.

discovery' (ὁδὸς . . . ἐπὶ τὴν εὕρεσιν) and speaks of moving from what is previously known to what is like it.²⁰ Along the same lines, 'inductive reasoning' (ἐπιλογισμός)—moving from the visible to the visible rather than from the visible to the invisible²¹—is said to be useful for (among other things) 'the discovery of things temporarily unclear (εἰς εὕρεσιν τῶν προσκαίρων ἀδήλων); for thus they themselves call what belongs to the realm of the perceptible but has not yet become plain'.²² Thus the general rule, as Celsus (the medical writer) indicates, was that one should work 'from things certain and sure' (*De med.*, proem. 31).

The compatibility of the Empiricists' 'way of discovery' and Irenaeus' 'art of discovery' is further suggested by the fact that both (as we shall see) were thought to guarantee agreement and to eliminate the variety of opinion found among those given to speculation (whether philosophers or Gnostics).

2. *What was God doing before he made the world?*

We turn now to the question held up by Irenaeus to illustrate the futility of such speculation—namely, 'What was God doing before he created the world?' (*antequam mundum faceret deus, quid agebat?*). It is a question (as we shall see) that also had a connection with Empiric medicine and Scepticism.

(a) Irenaeus' discussion of the point is intended to deflate speculation concerning the origin of the world: what God was doing before creation 'no Scripture reveals' and the answer must be left to God. Irenaeus, of course, has Gnostics in mind who, because they think they have discovered the origin of matter, feel free to condemn the creator (*Adv. haer.* 2. 28. 3). Under the circumstances it is natural to think that it was these very Gnostics who threw the question up to defenders of the creator. But that is hardly likely. For it is another debate that Irenaeus reflects when he goes on to affirm that the world was created, 'having a temporal beginning' (*temporale initium accipiens*). This, as we shall see, represents one of the possible positions in the philosophical debate as to whether the world is or is not eternal. When Irenaeus treats the question about God's pre-mundane activity as having a bearing on Gnosticism, that is no doubt because the Gnostics claimed to know so much about what it was that *did* go on before creation. But the question was originally intended to make a different point.²³

²⁰ Galen, *De sectis* 2 (ed. Helmreich, p. 3. 21).

²¹ Id., *On Medical Experience* 24–31 (tr. Walzer, pp. 132–55).

²² Id., *De sectis* (ed. Helmreich, p. 11. 8).

²³ Because the Manichaeans (unlike the Gnostics) were strict dualists and taught the eternity of the realm of darkness, the question concerning God's pre-mundane

That is shown in greater detail by Origen who also discusses the question, 'If the world had a beginning in time, what was God doing before the world began?' (*De princ.* 3. 5. 3). Origen explicitly declares that 'even the heretics' (the Gnostics) yield to Scripture on the point and agree with the orthodox (*De princ.* 3. 5. 1). The only difference is that, unlike the orthodox, the heretics do not know how to respond to the challenge. Origen evidently feels that he can do so because of the distinction that he draws between this visible world which may be said to have had a beginning in time and the long series of worlds that precede and follow it or, more fundamentally, the realm of pure spirits whose creation is seen as an eternal consequence of the divine nature (*De princ.* 3. 5. 3-4). Thus Origen finds it possible to agree with the pagan critics of Christian theology who say that God was never 'at ease' and that his goodness and power were never inactive²⁴ and at the same time can refuse to draw the conclusion that the visible world is eternal.

The discussion clearly reveals that the question about God's pre-mundane activity had no exclusive connection with Gnostic problems but reflected a central debate in the philosophy of the period.²⁵ Thus it is one of the main issues selected by Lucian to illustrate the pointlessness of philosophical speculation. He observes that some (he means the Aristotelians in particular) say that the cosmos is 'unborn and indestructible' whereas others (he has in mind especially certain Platonists) 'dared to give an account of the demiurge and the manner of the creation' (*Icaromenippus* 8). And he uses this disagreement of the authorities to discredit the whole enterprise, just as Irenaeus also reflects negatively on the disagreement engendered by the 'disputations of the Gentile philosophers' about such arcane problems (*Adv. haer.* 2. 27. 1). It is worth noting that Lucian's puzzled student of philosophy begins his inquiries with curiosity about natural phenomena (*Icaromenippus* 4) and moves on from there to the more abstruse matters in much the same way as Irenaeus.

(b) If Irenaeus uses perplexity about mundane matters to deflate speculation, Galen's Empiricist discusses the question of the

activity could be used appropriately by them in their polemic with catholic Christianity. Cf. Étienne Gilson, *The Christian Philosophy of Saint Augustine* (New York: Random House, 1960), pp. 190-1.

²⁴ He works out the point in detail also in *De princ.* 1. 4. 3-5.

²⁵ At the same time, Origen's discussion of theological method in the preface to his *De principiis* shows that the question as to 'what existed before this world or what will exist after it' could in his case also lead to cosmological speculation that moved in a Gnostic direction (1, praef. 7).

eternity of the world as one illustration of how many things there are in addition to medical matters 'which by the argument of the logos and your reasoning are quite unknown'.²⁶ Whether the world is originated or not (he claims) is not ascertainable and either opinion leads to unsatisfactory conclusions about God: (1) if a person holds that the world is eternal, the implication is that 'God did not create the world', 'that his providence cannot possibly extend through endless ages', and especially that 'the world continues to exist without requiring in any way the providence of God at all', for in this case the world is indestructible and has no need of God; (2) on the other hand, if a person holds that the world is originated, the implication is this: 'If there were a time when the universe did not yet exist, then God either of his own will neglected to do what was best and most perfect, or else he was not capable of accomplishing this thing. . . . The expression of either of these views is blasphemy. . . . For the assertion that God withheld himself from doing what is best . . . is to accuse him of utter slackness and negligence. If he had wished it, but could not accomplish it, this would be a sign of powerlessness and weakness on his part.'²⁷

Galen's Empiricist reflects the arguments on both sides of the question. On the one hand, a few Platonists such as Plutarch and Atticus understood the *Timaeus* to speak of a discrete act of creation by the demiurge. In this connection, Atticus argues that if the world is regarded as eternal, piety is overturned; for the implication is that there is no need of a creator to account for the excellence of the world; and thus Plato deprived the world of eternity 'in order not to deprive the world of providence'.²⁸ The reference to the irrelevance of providence and God in an eternal world has striking affinities with the Empiricist's first set of arguments.

The Empiricist's second set of arguments is connected with a line of thought known to us primarily from Philo's school essay on the eternity of the world where Aristotelian views (otherwise rejected by Philo) are elaborated in detail (*De aet. mund.* 39–51).²⁹ These

²⁶ Galen, *On Medical Experience* 19. 1 (tr. Walzer, p. 121).

²⁷ *Ibid.*, 19. 3 (pp. 122–3).

²⁸ Eusebius, *P.E.* 15. 6. 2. The same argument is already advanced by Philo (*De opif. mund.* 9). Even some of those who regarded the world as eternal saw the point. Thus Calvenus Taurus recognized that most people find a threat to 'providence' in the idea that there could be a cause that is not 'prior in time', and he argued that Plato spoke as he did in the *Timaeus* (leaving the impression that creation took place at a point in time) to avoid such misunderstanding (Philoponus, *De aet. mund.* 6. 21; ed. Rabe, p. 187. 6).

²⁹ John Dillon, *The Middle Platonists* (Ithaca, N.Y.: Cornell University Press, 1977), pp. 132–3.

views lived on and were ultimately taken up also by the Neoplatonists. Wallis summarizes the argument as follows:

Either things are better after the world's creation (or destruction) . . . or it is worse. But it is equally blasphemous to suppose either that God's activity alters for the worse, or that it was initially imperfect and so needed to change for the better. Or if the resulting state is neither better nor worse, any change is totally pointless.³⁰

Thus the world must be eternal. Evidently Galen's Empiricist has concentrated on one horn of the dilemma—namely, that creation represents a change for the better—and has constructed a new set of alternatives based on considerations of divine power and goodness.

What lay behind the Empiricist's formulation of the point can perhaps be made out. To begin with, it is to be noted that his concern for the possible 'slackness and negligence' of God has affinities with another side of the argument developed by Philo in his treatise on the eternity of the world. The basic question for Philo or his source is this: 'Why should God destroy the world?' (*De aet. mund.* 39). Two possibilities are dealt with: (a) that God might want to cease from world-making (40) and (b) that God might want to construct another world (41). It is the latter possibility that inspired the rebuttal summarized in the previous paragraph. The rejoinder to the first suggestion is that it is inconsistent with God, whose very nature it is—for whom 'it is necessary'—to be active in changing disorder into order. The thought goes back to Aristotle, who similarly connects necessity with eternal motion.³¹ Also note that when Origen's pagan opponents ask what God was doing before the world began, they go on to say: 'It is irreligious and also absurd to say that the nature of God is at ease (*otiosam*) and inactive (*immobilem*) or to think that his goodness (*bonitas*) ever failed to act beneficently and his omnipotence (*omnipotentia*) ever lacked its powers' (*De princ.* 3. 5. 3). The exposition of the theme here in terms of God's goodness and power indicates that the Empiricist's second set of arguments represents a recognized variation of the arguments first developed by Aristotle for the eternity of the world.

Now the question as to what God was doing before creating the world is natural and appropriate in the mouth of anyone who denied the possibility of God's idleness or inactivity. But evidently it was not often asked in so many words. The reason seems to be that it arose at the edges of the debate. I refer here to the Stoic doctrine of the conflagration which for some raised as many

³⁰ R. T. Wallis, *Neoplatonism* (London: Duckworth, 1972), p. 103.

³¹ Aristotle, *De caelo* 3. 2, 300^b21; *De anima* 1. 3, 407^b22.

questions about the eternity of the world as did Plato's *Timaeus* and the opening verses of Genesis. There was one Stoic, a certain Boethus, who departed from orthodoxy on the point and attacked the doctrine of the conflagration.³² One of his arguments (which again is preserved in Philo's treatise on the eternity of the world) is this: τί κατ' ἐκείνον ὁ θεὸς πράξει τὸν χρόνον; ἢ τὸ παράπαν οὐδέν; 'What will God be doing at that time [i.e. during the conflagration]? Nothing at all?' (*De aet. mund.* 83). Such a God, he goes on, will be convicted of 'idleness' (ἀργία) and 'inactivity' (ἀπραξία), and his 'immobility' (ἡρεμία) will lead to his death (*De aet. mund.* 84).

This must have been the point of departure for the question about God's pre-mundane activity reported by Irenaeus and Origen. To be sure, it has been adjusted to take account of the peculiarities of Christian doctrine. For now it is no longer a matter primarily of what it may be that God *will* be doing between the end of this world and the beginning of the next, but of what it may be that he *was* doing before the creation of this one and only world. Conceivably even this adjustment predated the encounter with Christianity; for it makes even better sense as an attack on an interpretation of Plato's *Timaeus* that Aristotle already reflects³³ and that is taken up again by Philo,³⁴ Atticus,³⁵ and others³⁶—namely, that this one and only world not only came into being (out of pre-existent matter) but will nevertheless also be preserved for ever by divine power.³⁷

Irenaeus was prepared to accept the naïve Scriptural view of the world as having a temporal beginning without pursuing the consequences. Others were not satisfied to leave it at that. Thus Philo thought that he could turn the fear of attributing to God 'a vast inactivity' (πολλὴν ἀπραξίαν) against Aristotle himself in favour of a doctrine of creation (*De opif. mund.* 7). Wolfson has suggested

³² Cf. Johannes von Arnim, *Stoicorum veterum fragmenta* (4 vols.; Leipzig: B. G. Teubner, 1903–24), iii, pp. 265–7; Max Pohlenz, *Die Stoa* (2 vols.; Göttingen: Vandenhoeck und Ruprecht, 1948–9), vol. i, pp. 185–6; vol. ii, p. 94.

³³ Aristotle, *De caelo* 1. 10, 280^a28; *Phys.* 8. 1, 251^b17. Cf. Eduard Zeller, *Die Philosophie der Griechen*, vol. ii. 1: *Sokrates und die Sokratiker, Plato und die alte Akademie* (Leipzig: Fues's Verlag [R. Reisland], 1889), p. 792 n. 1.

³⁴ Philo, *De aet. mund.* 13 (Plato's view), 14 (the literal reading of Plato preferred), 16 (a reference to Aristotle's literal reading of the *Timaeus* in *De caelo* 1. 10, 280^a28; *Phys.* 8. 1, 251^b17), 19 (Moses' view the same as Plato's).

³⁵ Eusebius, *P.E.* 15. 6. 1–7.

³⁶ e.g. Augustine, *De civ. dei* 10. 31.

³⁷ Origen's formulation of the question in terms both of 'what existed before this world' and of 'what will exist after it' (*De princ.* 1, praef. 7) indicates how easy it was to shift attention from one to the other depending on the details of the cosmology under discussion.

that he had in mind God's relative unimportance as a mover when compared with the importance of other motive causes in the Aristotelian scheme of things.³⁸ However that may be, Philo nevertheless hedged his doctrine of creation carefully: creation for him is a non-temporal act since time itself is conceived of as a product of the motion of the world (*De opif. mund.* 26–7; cf. *De aet. mund.* 52–4).³⁹ Thus there can be no question of before or after with God regarding the act of creation; at the same time (to judge from other passages) there was once when the world was not.⁴⁰ A similar concern evidently lies behind Arius' view that though the Word was generated (i.e. created) timelessly (*ἀχρόνως γεννηθείς*)⁴¹ and came into being before time,⁴² there nevertheless was once when he was not.⁴³ And the same is true of Augustine's more highly developed analysis of creation as a non-temporal act.⁴⁴ An important element in all this was the literal reading (unusual for the period) of the act of creation in the *Timaeus*⁴⁵ in conjunction with an emphasis in the interpretation of the same source on the link between time and the motion of the world.⁴⁶

Another effort to preserve the religious value of the naïve Biblical idea of creation and at the same time to avoid philosophical error is represented by Origen's conception of the realm of pure spirits as

³⁸ Harry Austryn Wolfson, *Philo* (2 vols.; Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard University Press, 1947), vol. i, pp. 295–300.

³⁹ Cf. Dillon, *The Middle Platonists*, pp. 132–3, 157–8 (but Dillon thinks that Philo advocated creation only in the sense that the world depends on an external cause; see n. 50 below). Philo also adopted the view of the *Timaeus* that the world would be preserved eternally by divine power, and he sometimes seems to suggest that God constructed the world out of pre-existent matter.

⁴⁰ Philo actually uses a looser form of the expression (looser because it may more readily be taken to imply the reality of time apart from cosmic motion and the temporal nature of the act of creation): 'There was once a time when it [the world] was not' (*De decal.* 58: *καὶ ἦν ποτε χρόνος ὅτε οὐκ ἦν*). Clearly Philo seeks to preserve some sense of the naïve biblical view of creation as a temporal act. Cf. Wolfson, *Philo*, vol. i, p. 311 n. 96.

⁴¹ *Ep. ad. Alex.* (in Athanasius, *De syn.* 16; *P.G.* 26. 709B).

⁴² *Ep. ad Euseb. Nicom.* (in Epiphanius, *Pan.* 69. 6. 6; Holl, vol. iii, p. 157. 12).

⁴³ Athanasius naturally argues that this is tantamount to saying that 'there was once a time when the Word was not' (*C. Arian.* 1. 11).

⁴⁴ Gilson, *The Christian Philosophy of Saint Augustine*, pp. 189–96.

⁴⁵ Especially important here is Plutarch, *De animae procreatione in Timaeo* 3–4, 1013A–F. See also nn. 33–6 above.

⁴⁶ Francis MacDonald Cornford, *Plato's Cosmology* (The Library of Liberal Arts; Indianapolis–New York: Bobbs-Merrill, n.d.), pp. 102–5 (cf. Aristotle, *Phys.* 8. 1, 251^b17; Philo, *De aet. mund.* 52). A further complication is that Plato could also be understood as saying that even the disordered motion of the pre-mundane state of affairs provided a kind of measure of time (cf. Dillon, *The Middle Platonists*, p. 253). But this possibility does not seem to figure significantly in the materials under discussion in this paper.

eternally created.⁴⁷ For Origen apparently assumed (with Aristotle and others) that time itself is eternal⁴⁸ and that thus 'there was no time when these things [i.e. created things] were not' (μη εἶναι χρόνον ὅτε οὐκ ἦν ταῦτα).⁴⁹ The logic of his position seems close to interpretations of Plato reflected in Calvenus Taurus (in an important analysis of the verb γέγονεν in *Timaeus* 38B) and advanced by Albinus and others to the effect that the world is eternal yet at the same time dependent on an extrinsic cause.⁵⁰ In this way a sense of man's subjection to God is preserved.

From a theological point of view, then, there is nothing trivial about the debate. At the same time, it is hard to see how progress could be made in trying to deal with it along the lines laid down in the philosophical tradition. However that may be, Irenaeus was evidently aware of some of the complexities of the issue and appalled by the endless and apparently fruitless subtlety of the discussion. He had learned a lesson from his exposure to philosophy, and he now sought to apply it to the problem of Gnosticism.

(c) We note finally that throughout the discussion of this issue Galen's Empiricist takes the existence of God and his governance of the world for granted. Only so can his point hold: the question of God and providence is one of many things other than medical matters 'which by the argument of the logos and your reasoning are quite unknown, but which we nevertheless must not avoid and hold aloof from because they have a being which is not evident'.⁵¹ Here again there is a link with Scepticism, surprising as that may seem. Thus Sextus Empiricus certainly knows all the metaphysical uncertainties that beset the problem of God, yet to avoid misunderstanding he prefaces his anti-dogmatic remarks on the topic with the affirmation 'that following common opinion we say undogmatically that there are gods and we venerate gods and say that they exercise providence' (*Pyrrh. hyp.* 3. 2-3). For the Sceptic's commitment to ancestral customs and laws includes such

⁴⁷ Cf. Henry Chadwick, *Early Christian Thought and the Classical Tradition* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1966), pp. 83-4.

⁴⁸ Aristotle, *Phys.* 8. 1, 251^b12; cf. Philo, *De aet. mund.* 52-3. Yet in the translation of his *Hom. in Genes.* 1 (ed. Baehrens, p. 2. 17) we are told that there was no time before creation. This seems to contradict the logic of his position as a whole.

⁴⁹ Photius, *Bibl. Cod.* 235 (P.G. 103. 1140D). Cf. *De princ.* 1. 2. 9-10; 1. 4. 3-5.

⁵⁰ Cf. Dillon, *The Middle Platonists*, pp. 242-4 (Calvenus Taurus), 286-7 (Albinus). Augustine knew Platonists who used the illustration of a footstep planted eternally in the dust: the footstep is eternal, yet some foot made the step (*De civ. dei* 10. 31). For references to Platonists from the time of Crantor to that of Proclus who adopted such a view see Harold Cherniss, *Plutarch's Moralia* (vol. xiii, part 1; Loeb Classical Library; Cambridge, Massachusetts: Harvard University Press; London: William Heinemann, 1976), p. 170 n. a.

⁵¹ Galen, *On Medical Experience* 19. 1 (tr. Walzer, p. 121).

respect for deity (*Pyrrh. hyp.* 1. 23–4; *Adv. math.* 9. 49). Similarly, when Carneades sought to show how impossible it is to draw a line between the divine and the natural, we are told that he did so ‘not so as to destroy the gods (for what could less befit a philosopher?) but in order to prove Stoic conceptions of the gods worthless’ (Cicero, *De nat. deor.* 3. 17. 44).

Thus in both Empirical and Sceptical circles Irenaeus could find a measure of sympathy for his view that it was enough to affirm divine providence without attempting to solve the metaphysical issues involved.

(d) There is a famous anti-speculative text from the Mishnah that deserves notice at this point. In a statement that may or may not be separable from its context, *Hagigah* 2. 1 says: ‘If anyone speculates about four things, it would have been merciful had he never come into the world—namely, what is above, what is below, what is before, and what is after.’ One exposition of the text reapplies Ecclus. iii. 21–2 to the problem: ‘Seek not things that are too hard for you, and search not out things that are hidden from you. The things that have been permitted you, think thereon; you have no business with things that are secret’ (*B. T. Hagigah* 13a). The statement in *Hagigah* 2. 1 is often regarded as directed not simply against speculation in general but against Gnosticism in particular. And it seems undeniable that there are anti-Gnostic elements in associated materials.⁵² But that the statement itself was originally anti-Gnostic is open to question.⁵³ For one thing, there is some evidence that at times ordinary philosophical questions came to the attention of the rabbis. Thus they seem to have dealt with the problem of the eternity of matter⁵⁴ and apparently also that of the creation of time.⁵⁵ I very tentatively suggest reading the statement from *Hagigah* 2. 1 in the light of such ordinary philosophical questions. Thus ‘what is above’ and ‘what is below’ may have to do with the question as to whether the All is circumscribed or not. And

⁵² For some of these elements see Ephraim E. Urbach, *The Sages, Their Concepts and Beliefs*, tr. Israel Abrahams (2 vols.; Jerusalem: Magnes Press, Hebrew University, 1975), vol. i, pp. 193–213.

⁵³ S. E. Loewenstamm, ‘On an Alleged Gnostic Element in Mishna Hagiga ii, 1’, in *Yehezkel Kaufmann Jubilee Volume*, ed. Menahem Haran (Jerusalem: Magnes Press, Hebrew University, 1960), pp. 112–21. Loewenstamm regards all four terms as originally having to do with space and as reflecting Ancient Near Eastern conceptions.

⁵⁴ Urbach, *The Sages*, vol. i, p. 188. Cf. Alexander Altmann, *Studies in Religious Philosophy and Mysticism* (Ithaca, New York: Cornell University Press, 1969), pp. 128–39.

⁵⁵ Urbach, *The Sages*, vol. i, pp. 210–12. Cf. Louis Ginzberg, *The Legends of the Jews* (7 vols.; Philadelphia: Jewish Publication Society of America, 1909–38), vol. v, p. 6 n. 14.

'what is before' and 'what is after' may refer to the question as to how God is occupied before or after this world.⁵⁶ Our previous discussion provides sufficient background for the second question. The first requires some orientation.

We note first that when Lucian singles out philosophical disputes that baffle the uninitiated, prominent among them is the question whether the universe is indestructible or not (the burden of our previous discussion) and (shortly after) the question whether the universe is finite or infinite, whether the All is circumscribed or not (*Icaromenippus* 8). The second of these is associated in Philo, the Church fathers, and apparently also the rabbis with their use of the formula 'containing, not contained' to proclaim the transcendence and omnipresence of God.⁵⁷ Thus it is not impossible that the two issues were often conjoined and appeared to the rabbis as together opening up dangerous questions about time and space. It should be observed that in the section of Irenaeus with which we have been dealing, there is also a reference to God as containing all things and contained by none (*Adv. haer.* 2. 25. 4) and that he elsewhere develops the formula in such a way that special attention is paid to the question as to what could possibly be above or below the one who contains all (*Adv. haer.* 2. 1. 2-3).

Thus the rabbinic reaction to speculation (whether Gnostic or philosophical) is not unlike that of Irenaeus. Yet the relation is not sufficiently close to suggest influence one way or the other. And if Loewenstamm is right that the four terms of *Hagigah* 2. 1 are all spatial,⁵⁸ there is even less reason to suspect a connection. In any event, Irenaeus is clearly more deeply indebted to Graeco-Roman sources for the intellectual tools that he uses in the debate. We return, then, to his discussion.

3. *Adherence to what is evident*

There runs through the whole discussion an emphasis on the importance of remaining satisfied with what is clear and obvious or generally accepted.

The sound mind, according to Irenaeus, attends to what 'God has given in the power of men and has subjected to our knowledge'.

⁵⁶ Compare Origen's formulation of the question in terms of 'what existed before this world or what will exist after it' (*De princ.* 1, praef. 7).

⁵⁷ William R. Schoedel, 'Enclosing, Not Enclosed: The Early Christian Doctrine of God', in *Early Christian Literature and the Classical Intellectual Tradition, In Honorem Robert M. Grant*, ed. William R. Schoedel and Robert L. Wilken (Théologie historique 53; Paris: Éditions Beauchesne, 1979), pp. 75-86; cf. Urbach, *The Sages*, vol. 1, pp. 66-79.

⁵⁸ See n. 53 above.

The sound mind will practise such things enthusiastically and make progress in them ‘by making learning easy for itself through daily exercise (διὰ τῆς καθημερινῆς ἀσκήσεως)’ in them. Such matters include ‘what falls under our glance’ (τὰ ὑπ’ ὄψιν πίπτοντα τὴν ἡμετέραν) or, in specifically Scriptural terms, ‘all that has been spoken clearly and unambiguously in so many words’. Thus especially in the interpretation of parables we are not to bring to bear ‘what has not been spoken openly (*aperte*) or what has not been placed before our eyes (*neque ante oculos posita*)’. Attention to such things is what leads to the kind of disagreement one finds among the pagan philosophers (*Adv. haer.* 2. 27. 1).

Irenaeus repeats much of this in what follows, but at times with interesting variations. The emphasis is on hearing what Scripture has to say ‘openly, without ambiguity, and in the same way by all’. At the same time, what Scripture clearly affirms (the existence of one God) is also plain to us ‘through what falls under our glance’ (*per ea quae in aspectum veniunt*) in nature (*Adv. haer.* 2. 27. 2). Thus in interpreting parables we should not abandon ‘what is certain, indubitable, and true’ (*Adv. haer.* 2. 27. 3). If there are difficulties in Scripture, that is understandable in the light of the fact that ‘even of those things which are before our feet (*ante pedes*)—I mean such as belong to this creation which we also handle and see and are in close contact with—many have escaped our knowledge and these very things we entrust to God’; and here there follows the passage about the causes of various natural phenomena (*Adv. haer.* 2. 28. 2). After repeating the comparison between Scripture and nature, Irenaeus goes on to say that if what is obscure in the Scriptures is understood in the light of what is clear, we shall see that the parables ‘will agree with what is clearly expressed’ (*Adv. haer.* 2. 28. 3).

Finally, Irenaeus again comments near the end of the section on the absurdity of the Gnostic claim to knowledge of heavenly things in the light of their ignorance of what is close at hand. Again he has in mind their ignorance of ‘the causes of those things which are in this world’—that is, things which (in a variation of a previous remark) ‘are in our hands (*in manibus*) and before our feet (*ante pedes*) and in our eyes (*in oculis*) and on earth (*in terrenis*)’ (*Adv. haer.* 2. 28. 9).

Van Unnik has examined the formula ‘before our feet’ and showed that it occurs widely in Greek and Latin literature in discussions that highlight the plain man’s jaundiced view of philosophers.⁵⁹ Originally the expression referred to what is before

⁵⁹ See n. 2 above.

our feet as opposed to what is in the sky. Thus in Plato's *Theaetetus* (174A) a maidservant laughs at Thales (who fell into a well while surveying the sky) 'that he should be so eager to know what was happening in the sky yet should miss what is there before his feet'. The spatial significance of the contrast is not forgotten as the formula is passed on. At the same time, there is a tendency (especially clear in Irenaeus) to see it primarily as a contrast between what is and is not accessible to the human mind. Finally, it is worth noting that just as Irenaeus expands the formula 'before our feet' (see the line from *Adv. haer.* 2. 28. 9 quoted in the previous paragraph), so Plato has Socrates speak (sympathetically, however) of the philosopher's ineptitude as he attempts to come to terms with 'what is at his feet and before his eyes' (*Theaet.* 174C).

Van Unnik has no doubt discovered an important clue to our understanding of Irenaeus' theological method. But similar expressions occur in discussions of Empiric medicine, and their use there helps us to grasp Irenaeus' point more precisely.

Thus Galen's Empiricist is appalled by the fact that the Dogmatist 'rejects what is obvious to the eye'.⁶⁰ And he goes on to list all the occupations in which people succeed by attending to what experience teaches them.⁶¹ In this connection, he contrasts the attitude of the thinker with that of the plain man. The former can, for example, discourse at length on the nature of mushrooms; but it takes an ordinary country-dweller to make a sound choice between those that are edible and those that are not. What makes the difference is that country-dwellers 'are familiar with them [i.e., mushrooms] and see them constantly'.⁶² In short, it is daily exercise (to use one of Irenaeus' expressions)⁶³ that gives them this ability. The basic position of the Empiricist is this: 'I for my part adhere to and follow that which is known to men, and accept what is obvious without inquiring into the cause of each individual thing'.⁶⁴ What makes knowledge systematic is that a thing is seen 'many times in the same way'.⁶⁵ Thus it is 'practice' that makes perfect.⁶⁶ And in

⁶⁰ Galen, *On Medical Experience* 9. 1 (tr. Walzer, p. 98).

⁶¹ Ibid. 9. 2–6 (pp. 98–100).

⁶² Ibid. 9. 4 (p. 99).

⁶³ *Adv. haer.* 2. 27. 1: the sound mind makes learning easy for itself 'through daily exercise' (διὰ τῆς καθημερινῆς ἀσκήσεως). Note that elsewhere Galen says that the Empiricists 'refer to the active exercise of experience as practice' (*eam enim que in operationibus exercitationem emperie triuim nominant* = τὴν γὰρ ἐν τοῖς ἔργοις ἀσκησιν τῆς ἐμπειρίας τριβὴν ὀνομάζουσιν; *Subfig. emp.* 3, with the retroversion into Greek from Deichgräber, *Empirikerschule*, p. 48, 22).

⁶⁴ Galen, *On Medical experience* 18. 1 (tr. Walzer, p. 119). Celsus also says that the Empiricists consider 'only what is easiest and does not go beyond what is commonplace' (*tantum facillima et non plus quam vulgaria*; *De med.*, prooem. 64).

⁶⁵ Galen, *On Medical Experience* 18. 2–5 (tr. Walzer, pp. 119–21).

⁶⁶ Ibid. 18. 4 (p. 120). Also see n. 63 above.

words that Irenaeus could have used to express his opinion of the Gnostics, the Empiricist has this to say concerning the Dogmatist:

Should you find solutions to your questions, then you may be sure that the answers you receive are vain, and that you only refute yourself by falling into error and by separating yourself from the truth. And if you get no answer to your questions, you have no right to reproach us or make a charge against us that the fact does not exist, for it is assuredly clear that it does exist. If, however, you cannot explain the cause of its existence, then you cannot believe in any of the visible things, to say nothing of others.⁶⁷

The important point here is that adherence to what is before our eyes and is clear and obvious is tied in with a rejection of the search for causes just as it is in Irenaeus. Similarly, Irenaeus agrees with the Empiricists that the effort to move from what is clear to what is unknowable leads to disagreement whereas adherence to what is obvious brings unanimity.⁶⁸ Moreover, just as the Empiricist believes that 'if [something] belongs to that which is not registered by observation and memory, then it is something far beyond the faculties of men, unattainable and impossible for him',⁶⁹ so Irenaeus asserts that 'if a person fails to find the cause of any of the things which are inquired into, let him realize that as man he is infinitely less than God' (*Adv. haer.* 2. 25. 3).⁷⁰ Again, there may be the suggestion in Irenaeus' formulation of the thought that the search for causes is not utterly hopeless, especially since he concludes the passage by remarking that because of divine goodness mankind is gradually learning from the Word the dispensations of God (*dispositiones dei*). Yet it is clear that for the most part Irenaeus is prepared to live with the epistemological limitations set by the method of Empiric medicine and Scepticism. Hence although his adherence to what is obvious may owe something to popular distrust of philosophy, such distrust has been focused more precisely under the influence of more highly developed intellectual tools.

The fact that Irenaeus used such tools indicates that Van Unnik's fear is misplaced that a reading of Irenaeus in terms of Scepticism makes the bishop a companion and forerunner of theologians who shortsightedly appeal to God to fill in gaps left by science.⁷¹ Such

⁶⁷ Galen, *On Medical Experience* 18. 6 (p. 121).

⁶⁸ *Ibid.*, 11. 2-4; 24. 1-31. 6 (pp. 103-4; 132-55); *De sectis* 5 (ed. Helmreich, p. 11, 16). Irenaeus makes the point especially in *Adv. haer.* 2. 27. 1 where he alludes to the divisions 'among the Gentile philosophers' caused by attention to what is beyond man's knowledge.

⁶⁹ Galen, *On Medical Experience* 30. 4 (tr. Walzer, p. 150).

⁷⁰ The sound mind, as he says elsewhere, attends only to what 'God has placed in the power of men and subjected to our knowledge' (*Adv. haer.* 2. 27. 1).

⁷¹ Van Unnik, 'Theological Speculation', p. 34.

a view depends on an insufficient appreciation of the depth of Irenaeus' indebtedness to Empiric method and Scepticism. For it is surely clear that he did more than merely exploit a doxographical source or appeal casually to a tough-minded 'discipline of discovery' for rhetorical effect. From a modern point of view, to be sure, he and his sources approached the problem of causal explanation too rigidly. And many of our contemporaries would regret the easy way in which he identifies the function of scientific and religious language. Nevertheless, the challenge thrown down to speculative thinking by Irenaeus remains an impressive achievement in the development of a sober theological method.

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